HISTORY OF AFRICAN THEATRE

The Yoruba Travelling Theatre

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

How a touring company worked: the leader, the repertory, the music, the money, and why the Yoruba travelling theatre became the model for popular performance in Nigeria.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- company structure
- repertory
- Ogunde
- Ogunmola
- music and audience

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A company, not a production

The travelling theatre was organised around a leader who wrote, composed, directed and often played the lead, with a permanent company of actors, musicians and dancers. It owned its own instruments, costumes and bus. It survived by touring: a new play opened in Lagos, toured the regional towns, and was replaced when the takings fell.

That economy shaped the plays. They had to please a paying audience immediately, so they combined music, dance, comedy, spectacle and a moral story. They were long, they changed in performance, and they were rewritten for each tour.

Ogunde and the professional company

Hubert Ogunde began with a church choir and a part-time concert party, and built a professional company that toured Nigeria from the mid-1940s. His plays drew on Yoruba folklore, on current politics and on the Bible, and his music - highlife, Yoruba chant, choral harmony - was as much the attraction as the plot.

His company's success showed that an African theatre could be commercially viable, and his clashes with colonial and later military authorities showed what political theatre costs. Both belong in the history.

Ogunmola and the actor's theatre

Kola Ogunmola came from the church concert tradition and made a theatre of the actor: long comic improvisations, a sharp satirical eye, and a company that could hold an audience with a single performer. His adaptation of Amos Tutuola's The Palm-Wine Drinkard showed that a novel could be turned into popular theatre without losing either.

What happened to it

Television, video and the cinema took the mass audience from the 1970s, and the travelling companies declined. Their influence did not: the Yoruba film industry inherited the repertoire, the music and the star system, and the stage companies' way of building a play around music and a moral survives in Nigerian popular theatre and in Nollywood's family dramas.

For a student company the lesson is practical: a repertory, a bus, a band and a loyal audience will take a play further than a single well-funded opening night.

The repertoire and the star

Travelling theatre was a star system. The leader's name was on the poster, the leader played the lead, the leader's music sold the tickets. The repertoire was built around that star: roles written to display a voice, a dance, a comic turn, and a moral authority the audience already associated with the performer.

The plays themselves were often adapted from folk tales, from novels, from the Bible and from the newspapers. The adaptation was free: a story was taken, reset in a recognisable world, given songs and a moral, and toured until it stopped earning. Copyright was not the model; ownership of a performance was.

For a student company the lesson is about the ensemble: a company built around one performer survives only as long as that performer. The travelling theatres that lasted built a repertoire and a training system, and trained the

next generation on the road.

The music as structure

In travelling theatre the music is not an interval act. A song establishes the world, marks a time jump, comments on the action and gives the audience a way into the story. The band is on stage, the leader sings, and the company answers.

Watch how the transition works: a spoken line becomes a phrase, the phrase becomes a melody, the melody becomes a chorus the audience already knows. That join is the form's signature, and it is the technique a modern Nigerian musical most needs to learn.

Exercises

1. Plan a three-town tour for a student company: repertoire, transport, venue, fee, and what changes between towns.
2. Take a folk tale and outline it as a travelling-theatre play with songs and a moral.
3. Compare the Ogunde and Ogunmola companies in organisation and performance style.

Where to read more

Ebun Clark, Hubert Ogunde: The Making of Nigerian Theatre (1979)

Karin Barber, The Generation of Plays (2000)

Yemi Ogunbiyi (ed.), Drama and Theatre in Nigeria (1981)

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